

Europe



The world's second-smallest continent has a great variety of landscapes, climates, and ethnic groups. Twice in the last century, conflict in Europe led to world war, but the continent is now largely at peace, with many countries members of the European Union.

United Kingdom



A small island kingdom that once ruled the largest empire in the history of the world.

43 CE Britain (Britannia) is invaded and conquered by the Romans.

410 The last Roman legions leave Britain. Over the next century Anglo-Saxon invaders push the native Celtic population out of the south and east of the island.

597 St. Augustine settles in Canterbury and begins to convert the kingdom of Kent to Christianity.

617 Northumbria establishes supremacy over the other six kingdoms of England.

757–96 Offa is king of Mercia and builds a defensive dike on the border between England and Wales.

793 Viking raids on Britain from Denmark and Norway begin.

802–39 Egbert is king of Wessex and, after defeating the Mercians in 825 and receiving the submission of Northumbria in 829, is recognized by his fellow kings as the first king of all England.

871–99 Alfred the Great is king of Wessex. In 891 Alfred orders the compilation of the *Anglo-Saxon Chronicle*, a record of the events of England that is continually updated until the 1100s. For his victories against the Danes, his wise rule, and his artistic patronage, Alfred is known as “the Great,” the only English king ever to be known by this title.

878 By the Treaty of Wedmore, Alfred divides England in two with the Danes. After the capture of London in 886, he is recognized as king of all England.

899 Edward the Elder and his successors as kings of Wessex expel most Danes and regain control of much of England.

1002 After a long period of peace, Viking raids are renewed by Sweyn Forkbeard, king of Denmark, who becomes king of England in 1013.

1016–42 England becomes part of a vast Scandinavian kingdom comprising Denmark, Norway, and much of Sweden, ruled over by Canute and his two sons.

1066 Norman conquest of England commences following the defeat of King Harold II (1066) at Hastings by the invading army of Duke William of Normandy. As William I, or “William the Conqueror” (1066–87), he crushes a succession of rebellions and starts an ambitious castle-building program, including the Tower of London.

1085 William orders the compilation of the Domesday Book, a record of the population, extent, value, state of cultivation, ownership, and tenancy of all the land in England.

1154–89 Henry II is the first Plantagenet king, controlling an Angevin empire through marriage and conquest that stretches from the Scottish border down to the Pyrenees in southern France.

1171 Supported by the pope, Henry invades Ireland to control potentially rebellious English and Irish nobles. The Irish kings and nobles pledge allegiance to Henry, marking the start of more than 700 years of English rule over Ireland.

1189 Richard I, “the Lionheart,” ascends the throne and spends almost all his 10-year reign abroad, fighting to regain Jerusalem during the crusades. Killed fighting in France, he is succeeded by his brother John (1199–1216).

1215 The Magna Carta, or Great Charter, is signed at Runnymede by King John and the English barons. This protects the nobility's rights against the excessive use of royal power in matters of taxation, justice, religion, and foreign policy. The charter lays down the respective rights and responsibilities of laymen and the church in relation to the power of the crown. Important at the time, the charter's relevance lessened as feudalism declined, and under the Tudors it was forgotten. It is now considered a milestone in English constitutional history.

1265 Representatives from the boroughs, as well as lords, clergy, and knights are summoned by Simon de Montfort to the first English parliament. The Model Parliament summoned by Edward I (1272–1307) in 1295 is even more representative in its composition.

1277 Edward I (1272–1307) invades Wales and overcomes Welsh resistance led by Prince Llywelyn II by 1282. In 1284 he ends Welsh independence by the Statute of Rhuddlan.

1301 Edward I makes his son Edward (later Edward II, 1307–27) the first Prince of Wales, a title given to all male heirs to the throne ever since.

1337–1453 The 100 Years War between England and France begins as Edward III lays claim to the French throne. Edward and his son, the Black Prince, win major victories at Crécy (1346) and Poitiers (1356). A treaty in 1360 gives Edward much land in return for renouncing his claim, but the French renew war in 1369 and drive the English out of many of their possessions by 1374.

1348–50 The Black Death sweeps across Europe and kills between one-third and one-half of the English population.

1381 Sparked by the imposition of a poll tax in 1380, serfs rebel in the Peasants' Revolt, led by Wat Tyler.

1399 Richard II is deposed by his cousin, Henry of Lancaster (Henry IV, 1399–1413), and murdered at the start of a period of conflict between the royal houses of Lancaster and York—the Wars of the Roses—that lasts until 1485.

1400–15 Owain Glyndwr leads major revolt in Wales against English rule.

1415 Henry V (1413–22) revives the 100 Years War and wins a major victory at Agincourt. Under the 1420 Treaty of Troyes, he becomes regent of France and heir to the French throne. However, he dies in 1422 before he can succeed. After 1429 the French, led by Joan of Arc, push the English out of France, finally ending the war in 1453.

1483 After the death of his father Edward IV (1461–70, 1471–83), the boy king Edward V disappears while in the

Tower of London, presumed murdered by his uncle, Richard III.

1485 Richard III (1483–85) is defeated and killed at Bosworth Field by the Lancastrian Henry Tudor, who becomes Henry VII (1485–1509).

1509–47 Henry VIII is king, ruling at first through Cardinal Wolsey.

1534 Following the pope's refusal to annul his marriage to Catherine of Aragon to allow him to marry Anne Boleyn, Henry VIII breaks with Roman Catholic Church, and becomes Supreme Head of the Church. After the end of his marriage to Anne Boleyn in 1536, he subsequently marries four more times.

1536–43 Although Wales has been subjugated since 1284, a political union of Wales with England is forged, giving the Welsh representation in parliament.

1536–39 The monasteries are dissolved in order to fund the government. An authorized Bible in English is published for the first time in 1539.

1541 Having broken the power of Ireland's feudal lords, Henry VIII adopts the title of King of Ireland.

1547–53 During the reign of Edward VI, England becomes a Protestant nation with an English Bible and prayer book.

1553 Mary, daughter of Catherine of Aragon and Henry VIII, becomes Mary I. She tries but fails to bring England back into the Catholic fold, burning many Protestants at the stake. Her childless marriage to Philip II of Spain, the leading Catholic monarch in Europe, makes her unpopular, as does loss in 1558 of Calais, the last English possession in France.

DECISIVE MOMENT

DEFEAT OF LLYWELYN THE LAST, 1282

Wales has a much older history as a nation than England. Driven out of England by the Anglo-Saxons in the 5th and 6th centuries, the Celts formed a number of principalities in Wales that were united in the early 1200s. When Edward I came to the English throne in 1272, he summoned the Welsh prince, Llywelyn II, to pay homage. When Llywelyn refused, Edward invaded in 1277 and exacted the homage. Llywelyn rebelled in 1282 and Edward invaded again. After the prince was killed that year in an ambush, Welsh morale was crushed and Edward swiftly reinforced his conquest by building castles such as Harlech (below) to subdue his new realm. The defeat established an English hegemony over Wales that endures today.

